THE BULLOCK PRESIDENCY

BOOK ONE: BEFORE

Chapter 6 — "Super Tuesday"

Monday, March 4, 2024 – Wednesday, March 6, 2024

COLD OPEN — "THE DAY BEFORE"

EXT. U.S. SUPREME COURT — FIRST STREET NE — WASHINGTON, D.C. — MORNING

SUPER: MONDAY, MARCH 4, 2024 — 9:52 AM EST

SUPER: ONE DAY UNTIL SUPER TUESDAY

Gray marble under a gray sky. "EQUAL JUSTICE UNDER LAW" carved above the columns. A thicket of television cameras on the plaza. Reporters in raincoats holding phones up to refresh the Court's website. A handful of protesters with signs on both sides: "LET THE VOTERS DECIDE" and "INSURRECTIONISTS CAN'T RUN."

At the edge of the press pen, alone, in a black trench coat, with a legal pad clutched to her chest like a shield: ARIANNA CUMMINGS (31). She took the red-eye from Los Angeles. She has not slept.

A YOUNG COURT REPORTER (20s) from a legal news site recognizes her.

YOUNG COURT REPORTER
You're Arianna Cummings. Justice Cole. Bullock's lawyer.

ARIANNA
I'm counsel to the campaign.

YOUNG COURT REPORTER
You think this one affects you?

ARIANNA
I think a ruling that says states can't decide on their own who's qualified to be President affects everyone who's ever been told they're not qualified to be President.

YOUNG COURT REPORTER
That's a good quote.

ARIANNA
I've had all night to write it.

SUPER: 10:00 AM EST

Phones buzz in unison across the plaza. Gasps. Someone shouts it out loud.

REPORTER (O.S.)
NINE TO NOTHING! It's unanimous! Trump stays on the ballot!

Arianna is reading on her phone, scrolling fast. Per curiam. Unanimous judgment. States may not enforce Section 3 of the Fourteenth Amendment against federal candidates; that power belongs to Congress.

She stops scrolling. Reads one paragraph twice. Closes her eyes.

ARIANNA
(whispering)
...A patchwork. They said a "patchwork."

YOUNG COURT REPORTER
What?

ARIANNA
They're worried about different states reaching different answers about the same national candidate. That's my whole argument. That's Alabama.

SCOTUSBLOG — 10:04 AM EST

Supreme Court unanimously rules Colorado cannot remove Trump from ballot

The justices say states lack the power to enforce Section 3 against federal candidates; Congress must act.

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Supreme Court restores Trump to ballot, rejecting state efforts to bar him over Jan. 6

EXT. U.S. SUPREME COURT — PLAZA — AFTERNOON

SUPER: 2:31 PM EST

The cameras have mostly packed up. Arianna is sitting on the cold marble steps with a cup of coffee from a cart. Her phone rings. "ELXA."

ARIANNA
Tell me.

ELXA (V.O.)
The Court just issued an order in Bullock v. Allen. Grant. Vacate. Remand. "For further consideration in light of Trump v. Anderson."

Arianna stands up so fast she spills the coffee.

ARIANNA
They vacated the Eleventh Circuit.

ELXA (V.O.)
They vacated the Eleventh Circuit.

ARIANNA
Then he goes back on the ballot in Alabama —

ELXA (V.O.)
Arianna. The Alabama Secretary of State put out a statement four minutes later. The ballots are printed. Absentee voting closed. Polls open in sixteen hours. He says there's no lawful way to add a candidate overnight and he'll "comply with whatever the lower courts ultimately decide." In April.

A long silence. Arianna looks up at the columns. At "EQUAL JUSTICE UNDER LAW."

ARIANNA
...So we won, and it doesn't count.

ELXA (V.O.)
Not tomorrow. Patti says to tell you it counts in Chicago. The credentials committee. Fifty-two Alabama delegates awarded under a ruling the Supreme Court just vacated. That's a convention fight. That's August.

ARIANNA
That's a convention fight.

ELXA (V.O.)
Come home, counselor. Marc wants you at the Shrine tomorrow night. He says, and I quote, "the most dramatic person on the campaign deserves the best seat."

ARIANNA
...Tell him I'm the second most.

She hangs up. Picks up her legal pad. Writes on a fresh page: "ALABAMA — CREDENTIALS CHALLENGE — DNC — CHICAGO — AUG 19."

Underlines it.

POLITICO — 3:12 PM EST

Supreme Court tosses ruling that kept Bullock off Alabama ballot — but it's too late for Super Tuesday

The order, citing the Trump decision, sets up a potential credentials fight at the Democratic convention over Alabama's 52 delegates.

Twitter · @ArianaCummingsEsq

We won in the Supreme Court today. We'll lose in Alabama tomorrow anyway. That's the law. See you in Chicago.

41K Retweets · 288K Likes

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

ARIANNA CUMMINGS WON AT THE SUPREME COURT AND STILL HAS TO WATCH ALABAMA GO TO BIDEN. JUSTICE COLE COULD NEVER.

22K Retweets · 140K Likes

ACT ONE — "THE VOTE"

MONTAGE — SUPER TUESDAY — MARCH 5, 2024 — MORNING

— 7:00 AM EST. RICHMOND, VIRGINIA. A line outside an elementary school in the rain. Students from VCU in "BET." hats. Older Black voters in church clothes. A woman with a stroller holding a "BIDEN 2024" umbrella.

— 7:30 AM EST. RALEIGH, NORTH CAROLINA. A church fellowship hall serving as a polling place. Outside, under a canopy with a thermos of coffee, shaking hands with every voter over sixty like he's their nephew: CORNELIUS SMILLEY (65). A BIDEN-HARRIS lapel pin. A pastor beside him.

CORNELIUS
(to an elderly voter)
Mother Hawkins. You look beautiful. You go on in there and do the right thing.

MOTHER HAWKINS (80s)
I'm votin' for Joe, baby. But my grandbaby's votin' for the other one. The boy with the hat.

CORNELIUS
(a smile that doesn't reach his eyes)
Grandbabies have their own minds, Mother Hawkins. Mine do too.

— 7:00 AM CST. HOUSTON, TEXAS. A library in Meyerland. Roy Chapman (66), in a Navy veteran's cap and a windbreaker, at the check-in table. A POLL WORKER (50s) slides him a form.

POLL WORKER
Republican or Democratic ballot, sir?

Roy hesitates for exactly one second. Behind him, Tyler (32) is holding his breath.

ROY
...Democratic.

The poll worker looks up. Raises an eyebrow. She's seen Roy vote in this library for twenty years.

POLL WORKER
Roy Chapman. Democratic.

ROY
Don't make it a whole thing, Darlene.

— 9:15 AM PST. BEL AIR. A vote center in a community room at a church on Sunset Boulevard. Marc (32) and Esther (31), in jeans and sweaters, with Emma and Victoria (11) and four Secret Service agents. Photographers outside the door, kept back by the sidewalk.

At the electronic ballot station, Marc pulls the privacy curtain. Emma and Victoria peek under it. He shoos them. They peek again.

VICTORIA
(whispering)
Did you vote for yourself?

MARC
(from behind the curtain)
That's private.

VICTORIA
You definitely voted for yourself.

MARC
I voted for the best candidate. It's a coincidence.

He steps out. A POLL WORKER (70s), tiny, white-haired, a retired schoolteacher, hands him an "I VOTED" sticker. He bends down so she can put it on his chest herself.

POLL WORKER (70s)
I taught kindergarten for thirty-eight years. I've never once had a student run for President.

MARC
Well, ma'am, I don't think I would've been your favorite.

POLL WORKER (70s)
You'd have been my favorite and my biggest problem. That's usually the same child.

Esther laughs out loud. Emma nods solemnly.

EMMA
That's true. Footnote.

Instagram · @esthersmilleybullock

[Photo: Marc bending down so a tiny poll worker can put an "I VOTED" sticker on him, the twins photobombing] Caption: "My favorite and my biggest problem." — Mrs. Edna, 38 years of kindergarten, who has met my husband for four minutes and already knows everything. Go vote.

19.4M likes

Twitter · @TylerChapmanMusic

Can't say who. Can't say what ballot. Can only say my daddy came out of the Meyerland library and said "Don't make it a whole thing" and then bought me breakfast tacos, which he has not done since 2006.

61K Retweets · 410K Likes

INT. ABC NEWS — ELECTION HEADQUARTERS — TIMES SQUARE — NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, MARCH 5, 2024 — 6:58 PM EST / 3:58 PM PST

The full election-night machine: the giant map, the Decision Desk behind glass, the countdown clocks. Tonight the screen shows sixteen of them, one for each contest, ticking toward their poll-closing times.

DAVID MUIR (50) and GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (63) at the center desk. The ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR at the map.

DAVID MUIR
Good evening, and welcome to our special coverage of Super Tuesday. The biggest night of the primary season. Sixteen contests on the Democratic side, fifteen on the Republican side, more than a third of each party's delegates. We are about to find out tonight whether either race is effectively over, or whether both are just getting started.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
And let's be precise about one thing up front. No Democratic candidate can mathematically clinch the nomination tonight. There are about fourteen hundred and twenty pledged delegates at stake, it takes nineteen sixty-eight to win, and neither Marc-Anthony Bullock nor President Biden has more than about a hundred and ten going in. The question tonight isn't whether someone clinches. It's whether someone builds a lead so large that the race is effectively over.

DAVID MUIR
On the Republican side, Donald Trump can't clinch tonight either. But if he sweeps, the pressure on Nikki Haley to leave the race will be enormous. Polls close in Virginia and Vermont in less than two minutes.

CHYRON: SUPER TUESDAY — 16 CONTESTS — 1,420 DEM / 865 GOP DELEGATES — FIRST POLLS CLOSE 7 PM EST

INT. SHRINE AUDITORIUM — BACKSTAGE — LOS ANGELES — SAME TIME

SUPER: 3:59 PM PST

The Shrine. A 1926 Moorish-revival palace across from USC, where the Oscars, the Grammys, and the Emmys have all been handed out. Its dressing rooms have seen a century of nervous celebrities.

Tonight, the largest dressing room has become the war room. Old Hollywood mirrors framed in light bulbs. A dozen laptops. A whiteboard with the sixteen states listed down the left side. A map of Virginia taped to a makeup mirror.

Patti Grove (60), on a stool, headset on, staring at a screen of county returns that doesn't have any returns yet. Elxa (33), standing. Grace (29), with three phones in a fan like a poker hand. Amond (32), on a vintage velvet chaise. Arianna (31), back from Washington, still in the black trench coat. Tayia (32), eating a Twizzler. Dante Reyes (43), in the doorway with the Secret Service SPECIAL AGENT IN CHARGE, a tall, quiet woman named AGENT RUTH OKONJO (48).

Marc (32) sits in a makeup chair in front of a mirror rimmed in light bulbs, staring at his own reflection. Esther (31) behind him with her hands on his shoulders.

PATTI
Sixty seconds to Virginia. Here's what's going to happen, so nobody has a heart attack. Vermont: they'll call it for us at seven sharp. It's Vermont. Bernie country. We're up thirty. Virginia: "too close to call." It'll be too close to call for hours. Northern Virginia counts late. Richmond counts late. Do not panic about Virginia until midnight.

GRACE
What about after midnight?

PATTI
After midnight you can panic. I'll join you.

MARC
(to his reflection)
I look tired.

ESTHER
You look like a man who did eleven rallies in seven states in six days.

MARC
Twelve. You weren't at the Little Rock one. It was at a Waffle House.

ESTHER
That wasn't a rally. You just walked into a Waffle House.

MARC
And sixty people followed me. That's a rally.

INT. ABC NEWS ELECTION HEADQUARTERS — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 7:00:00 PM EST

The chime. The whoosh.

DAVID MUIR
It is seven o'clock on the East Coast, and polls have closed in Virginia and Vermont. ABC News can project: in the Vermont Democratic primary, Marc-Anthony Bullock is the winner.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS PROJECTS: BULLOCK WINS VERMONT (DEM)

DAVID MUIR
In Virginia's Republican primary, ABC News projects Donald Trump the winner. The Vermont Republican primary is too early to call. And in Virginia's Democratic primary, between Bullock and the President...

A new graphic.

DAVID MUIR
...too close to call.

CHYRON: VIRGINIA DEM: TOO CLOSE TO CALL

INT. SHRINE — WAR ROOM — CONTINUOUS

A small cheer for Vermont. Patti doesn't look up.

PATTI
Told you. Sixteen delegates. Cute. Moving on.

MONTAGE — THE CALLS — 7:30 PM TO 10:15 PM EST

A rapid sequence on the ABC broadcast, each projection with its chime and graphic, intercut with reactions.

SUPER: 7:30 PM EST

DAVID MUIR (V.O.)
Polls have closed in North Carolina. In the Republican primary, ABC News projects Donald Trump. In the Democratic primary: too close to call.

SUPER: 8:00 PM EST

DAVID MUIR (V.O.)
Eight o'clock. A wave of projections. On the Democratic side: in Alabama, where Bullock does not appear on the ballot, ABC News projects President Biden. In Tennessee, President Biden. In Massachusetts, Marc-Anthony Bullock. In Maine, Bullock. Oklahoma and Texas: too early to call.

On the map: AL and TN go blue (Biden's color on ABC's Democratic map: dark blue). MA and ME go teal (Bullock).

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (V.O.)
On the Republican side, Donald Trump sweeps Alabama, Tennessee, Oklahoma, Maine, and Massachusetts, and we project him the winner in Texas the moment the polls close.

INT. MARRIOTT — SUITE 1104 — RALEIGH, NORTH CAROLINA — NIGHT

SUPER: 8:04 PM EST

The same suite as last week. Cornelius, in shirtsleeves, three phones, a precinct map of Wake County, Durham, Mecklenburg. On the TV: Alabama and Tennessee go to Biden.

A young BIDEN CAMPAIGN AIDE (26) in the doorway, breathless.

BIDEN CAMPAIGN AIDE
Mr. Smilley, Wilmington's asking about North Carolina. Durham's coming in strong for Bullock. The college precincts. Duke, Central. They're nervous.

CORNELIUS
Durham counts first. Durham always counts first. Tell Wilmington to wait for Halifax. Edgecombe. Northampton. Hertford. Bertie. The Black Belt counties. They count slow because the precincts are small and the poll workers are eighty years old and they do it by the book.

BIDEN CAMPAIGN AIDE
How do you know?

CORNELIUS
Because I've known half of those poll workers since 1976. Tell Wilmington to breathe.

The aide leaves. Cornelius sits. Looks at the framed card propped beside the lamp. "Footnote: This is true."

His phone buzzes. A text from NEIL. He looks at it. Doesn't open it. He hasn't opened a text from Neil in five days.

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — PARLOR — ATLANTA — SAME TIME

SUPER: 8:06 PM EST

Odessa (95). Lorraine (62). And Neil (39), who still lives five miles away but has been here every night since last Thursday.

ODESSA
He didn't answer?

NEIL
He hasn't answered since Thursday.

Odessa sets down her coffee.

ODESSA
Tell me again what he said. At the table. When you told him.

Neil takes a breath. FLASHBACK INTERCUT — the same parlor, Thursday, February 29, 2024. Cornelius standing at the head of the dining table. Neil across from him, standing too. Odessa and Lorraine seated.

NEIL (FLASHBACK)
Daddy, I'm endorsing Marc this afternoon. At the Capitol. I wanted you to hear it from me first. At this table. Like a Smilley.

CORNELIUS (FLASHBACK)
(long silence, then very calm)
You're forty years old in three weeks, Neil. Forty years old, and you've finally found something to believe in. And it's him.

NEIL (FLASHBACK)
It's not him, Daddy. It's me. It's the first thing I've ever done that you didn't tell me to do.

CORNELIUS (FLASHBACK)
Then I hope it keeps you warm.

He walks out of the dining room. END FLASHBACK.

Back in the present, Odessa shakes her head slowly.

ODESSA
"I hope it keeps you warm." His father said that to him in 1977 when he went to Morehouse instead of the seminary. Word for word. I was standing right there.

LORRAINE
He doesn't know he's saying it.

ODESSA
They never do, baby. That's how it gets passed down. Like china.

BACK TO: ABC NEWS ELECTION HEADQUARTERS

SUPER: 8:30 PM EST

DAVID MUIR
Polls have closed in Arkansas. ABC News projects President Biden the winner of the Arkansas Democratic primary.

SUPER: 9:00 PM EST

DAVID MUIR
Nine o'clock. Polls have closed in Colorado and Minnesota. ABC News projects Marc-Anthony Bullock the winner in both the Colorado and Minnesota Democratic primaries. And Iowa Democrats have released the results of their mail-in caucus: Bullock, fifty-two percent; Biden, forty-four.

On the map: CO, MN, IA turn teal.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
So by our count, Bullock has now won six contests tonight: Vermont, Massachusetts, Maine, Colorado, Minnesota, and Iowa. The President has won three: Alabama, Tennessee, and Arkansas, all in the South. And the big states, Texas, California, North Carolina, and Virginia, are all still out.

DAVID MUIR
George, is this the "split" scenario everyone was talking about?

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
So far, it's exactly the split. The President is winning the South, where he's dominating among older Black voters. Bullock is winning everywhere else. Which means everything comes down to the four big ones.

INT. SHRINE — WAR ROOM — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 6:04 PM PST

PATTI
Exactly the split. Exactly. Everybody breathe.

GRACE
We lost three states!

PATTI
We lost three states we were always going to lose, Grace. We weren't even on the ballot in one of them. We won six. Including three he thought he'd split with us. Breathe.

Marc is out of the makeup chair now, pacing the back of the room, the Secret Service agent watching him like a nervous parent at a playground.

MARC
What about Durham?

PATTI
Durham's ours. Big. Charlotte's ours. Greensboro is close.

MARC
And the rest?

Patti doesn't answer right away. She scrolls. Zooms in on a map of northeastern North Carolina. Small rural counties. Barely any votes in yet.

PATTI
The rest is your father-in-law.

Esther, by the mirror, looks up.

INT. CHAPMAN HOUSE — MEYERLAND, HOUSTON — NIGHT

SUPER: 8:22 PM CST / 9:22 PM EST

Roy (66) in the recliner. Tyler (32) on the couch, laptop open, the Texas Secretary of State's results page. On TV: "TEXAS DEM: TOO EARLY TO CALL — BULLOCK LEADS."

TYLER
Harris County's coming in. We're up nine in Harris. Up twenty in Travis. Bexar's close. El Paso's close. The Valley...

ROY
The Valley's gonna go for Biden.

TYLER
How do you know?

ROY
Because I worked with forty guys from McAllen and Brownsville at the refinery, and every one of 'em's mama loved Joe Biden, because Joe Biden goes to Mass every Sunday, and their mamas know it, and they've been voting for him since Obama.

Tyler stares at his father.

TYLER
Daddy, that might be the most accurate political analysis I've heard all year.

ROY
It's not analysis. It's lunch breaks. Thirty-one years of lunch breaks.

Tyler refreshes. Then again.

TYLER
...The Valley's going Biden.

ROY
Told you.

TYLER
But not by enough. Collin. Denton. Williamson County. Fort Bend. Suburbs. Crossover precincts. Those are Republican suburbs, Daddy, and they're showing up in the Democratic primary.

Roy leans forward in the recliner. Squints at the screen.

ROY
How many of those people are like me?

TYLER
Based on the turnout, maybe a hundred thousand? Two hundred?

Roy sits back. Quiet for a moment.

ROY
...Huh. I thought I was the only one.

TYLER
Nobody's ever the only one, Daddy.

INT. HALEY CAMPAIGN — PRIVATE RESIDENCE — CHARLESTON (KIAWAH ISLAND), SOUTH CAROLINA — NIGHT

SUPER: 9:41 PM EST

No election-night party. No ballroom. Haley is spending Super Tuesday privately with family and a few senior aides. The handful of staff are gathered in a rented beach house's living room. Ocean wind against the windows. A television on mute.

Simone Smilley (36) is on the back deck, alone, coat wrapped around her, phone in hand. The sound of the surf. Through the window behind her, the TV map is almost entirely red: Trump, Trump, Trump.

Her phone lights up. The family group text. A thread called "SMILLEY GRANDKIDS (NO PARENTS)" that Victoria started in December without asking anyone.

VICTORIA — 6:41 PM PST

AUNTIE SIMONE how is your lady doing

SIMONE — 9:42 PM EST

Not great, Vic.

EMMA — 6:43 PM PST

We're sorry. Daddy says she's smart and brave. Footnote: he said "smart and brave but wrong about almost everything," but the first part is the important part.

SIMONE — 9:44 PM EST

Tell your daddy I said that's the nicest thing a Democrat has ever said about her.

VICTORIA — 6:45 PM PST

Are you going to be sad?

Simone looks out at the dark ocean for a long time.

SIMONE — 9:47 PM EST

Little bit. Then I'll be fine. Smilleys always are.

EMMA — 6:47 PM PST

Granddaddy says that too.

Simone stares at that one. Doesn't answer.

BACK TO: ABC NEWS ELECTION HEADQUARTERS

SUPER: 9:47 PM EST

DAVID MUIR
And ABC News can now project: in North Carolina, President Biden wins the Democratic primary.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS PROJECTS: BIDEN WINS NORTH CAROLINA (DEM)

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
A significant win for the President. Bullock dominated in Durham, Charlotte, and the college towns. But the President ran up enormous margins in the rural Black Belt counties of the northeast, where turnout among older Black voters was extraordinary. ABC News' exit polls show Biden won Black voters over fifty in North Carolina by more than forty points.

DAVID MUIR
That firewall again.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
That firewall again.

INT. MARRIOTT — SUITE 1104 — RALEIGH — CONTINUOUS

The young aide bursts in, ecstatic.

BIDEN CAMPAIGN AIDE
They called it! North Carolina! Wilmington says the President wants to call you personally —

Cornelius doesn't stand. Doesn't smile. He's looking at the TV, at the map: North Carolina dark blue, Virginia still gray. Texas still gray. California not even closed.

CORNELIUS
Tell the President I'm grateful. Tell him North Carolina was the easy one.

BIDEN CAMPAIGN AIDE
Easy? We won by five.

CORNELIUS
Five is what Halifax County gives you when you've known the pastors for fifty years. Five isn't a firewall, son. Five is a sandbag.

The aide's smile fades.

CORNELIUS
Get me Virginia. Precinct by precinct. Prince William. Henrico. Petersburg. Norfolk. And book me a flight to Atlanta tomorrow afternoon.

BIDEN CAMPAIGN AIDE
Atlanta? Georgia's not till next week.

CORNELIUS
Exactly.

INT. SHRINE — WAR ROOM — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 6:48 PM PST

The room is quiet after the North Carolina call. Not devastated. Quiet. Marc stands in front of the TV with his arms crossed.

MARC
He did that.

ESTHER
He did.

MARC
He knows every pastor in every county in the Carolinas.

ESTHER
Since before I was born.

Marc turns away from the TV. He doesn't look angry. He looks like a man studying a chess position he respects.

MARC
Then I need to meet the pastors. Not the ones he knows. Their grandkids. The ones who'll be pastors in twenty years.

PATTI
That's a ten-year plan.

MARC
I'm thirty-two, Patti. I've got time.

BACK TO: ABC NEWS ELECTION HEADQUARTERS

SUPER: 10:00 PM EST

DAVID MUIR
Ten o'clock. Polls have closed in Utah. ABC News projects Marc-Anthony Bullock the winner of the Utah Democratic primary.

SUPER: 10:15 PM EST

DAVID MUIR
And in Oklahoma, where Bullock was restored to the ballot by the state Supreme Court just a week ago, ABC News projects President Biden the winner, narrowly.

SUPER: 10:52 PM EST

The chime. A bigger whoosh.

DAVID MUIR
A major projection now. ABC News projects that Marc-Anthony Bullock will win the Texas Democratic primary.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS PROJECTS: BULLOCK WINS TEXAS (DEM) — 244 DELEGATES

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Texas. Two hundred and forty-four delegates. The second-biggest prize of the night. And the story here, David, is crossover. Texas has an open primary. Any registered voter can choose either ballot. Our exit polls show nearly one in seven voters in the Texas Democratic primary today identified as Republicans or Republican-leaning independents. And they went overwhelmingly for Bullock.

DAVID MUIR
Republicans voting in the Democratic primary for the Democratic challenger.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
In Texas. In numbers we've never seen.

INT. CHAPMAN HOUSE — MEYERLAND — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:52 PM CST

Tyler is on his feet, both arms over his head, silent-screaming. Roy, in the recliner, doesn't move. He just nods once. Slowly.

ROY
One in seven.

TYLER
ONE IN SEVEN, DADDY.

ROY
Don't yell. Your mama's asleep.

TYLER
(whisper-screaming)
ONE. IN. SEVEN.

Roy picks up his phone. Puts on his reading glasses. Opens a text. Types slowly with one finger.

> **ROY CHAPMAN — to MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK — 9:54 PM CST**
>
> Mr. Bullock. Roy Chapman, Tyler's father. Congratulations on Texas. I voted for you. Don't make it a whole thing. — R.C.

Thirty seconds later, a reply:

> **MARC — 7:54 PM PST**
>
> Mr. Chapman. I'm making it a whole thing. I'm framing this. I'm hanging it next to the DOT letter. Thank you, sir. — M.A.B.

Roy reads it. Takes off his reading glasses. Looks at the wall for a long time. Then he gets up, goes to the garage, and comes back with the faded "TRUMP 2020" yard sign. He puts it in the recycling bin by the back door. Doesn't say a word about it.

Tyler watches him do it with his mouth hanging open.

ROY
It was taking up space.

INT. DONOHUE ESTATE — LIBRARY — HOLMBY HILLS — SAME TIME

SUPER: 7:55 PM PST

Victor (77), Joan (75), Robert (55), and Natasha (52). The TV shows ABC, which Natasha runs, covering her son, whom she is forbidden to discuss with ABC.

When Texas is called, Joan claps her hands once. Victor laughs. Robert smiles. Natasha doesn't move.

VICTOR
Texas, Natasha.

NATASHA
I saw, Daddy.

VICTOR
A hundred years ago, my grandfather couldn't buy land in Burbank under his own name. Tonight, Republicans in Texas crossed party lines to vote for his great-great-grandson.

A silence. Joan reaches over and takes Victor's hand.

JOAN
Your grandfather would have had a lot to say about that.

VICTOR
My grandfather would have said, "Good. Now sell them a ticket to Dreamland."

Robert laughs. Natasha finally cracks the smallest smile.

ROBERT
Tasha.

NATASHA
I can't, Robert. Not yet. California hasn't closed. Virginia hasn't been called. And the network I run is going to call both of them in the next three hours, and I'm going to sit here and not pick up the phone.

JOAN
(gently)
You can be proud and silent at the same time, baby. I was proud and silent for fifty years. It's a skill.

Natasha looks at her mother. Something passes between them. Something about Atlanta and old photographs.

ACT TWO — "CALIFORNIA"

INT. SHRINE AUDITORIUM — MAIN HALL — NIGHT

SUPER: 7:58 PM PST / 10:58 PM EST

The Shrine's main hall. Six thousand seats, every one full, plus a thousand people standing. The proscenium arch is dressed in navy and white. A giant screen shows ABC's coverage. "LET'S FIX IT" banners. A sea of "BET." hats.

In a reserved box on the side: Emma and Victoria (11), and LYRIC BAKER (9), with Harmony (31), Tyrese's empty seat with a "RESERVED — SABBATICAL" card on it (Grace's idea), and BET the dog, illegally, in Lyric's lap.

On the screen: the California countdown. 00:01:30.

LYRIC
Is California a big one?

EMMA
Four hundred and twenty-four delegates. More than a tenth of the whole thing.

LYRIC
Is that a lot?

VICTORIA
Lyric, it's California. It's where we LIVE.

LYRIC
So we win?

EMMA
They don't count it all tonight. California takes weeks. But they can "project" it.

LYRIC
What's project?

EMMA
It's when the TV is very sure but not totally sure.

VICTORIA
Like when Daddy says "we'll see" about getting a pony.

EMMA
No. "We'll see" means no. "Project" means yes.

Lyric considers this seriously.

LYRIC
I hope they project.

INT. ABC NEWS ELECTION HEADQUARTERS — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 11:00:00 PM EST / 8:00:00 PM PST

The chime.

DAVID MUIR
It is eleven o'clock on the East Coast, eight o'clock in the West, and the polls have closed in California. And based on our exit polling and early returns, ABC News can project: Marc-Anthony Bullock is the winner of the California Democratic primary.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS PROJECTS: BULLOCK WINS CALIFORNIA (DEM) — 424 DELEGATES

DAVID MUIR
The biggest prize of the night goes to the thirty-two-year-old native Californian, in his home state. And ABC News also projects that Donald Trump wins the California Republican primary.

INT. SHRINE AUDITORIUM — MAIN HALL — CONTINUOUS

The Shrine has been shaken by a lot of applause in a hundred years. Nothing like this.

Seven thousand people come to their feet at once. A roar that rattles the gilded ceiling. Confetti cannons fire early. Somebody on the floor starts the chant, and it rolls up to the balcony and back down:

CROWD
BET! BET! BET! BET!

In the box, Lyric stands on her seat, holding BET the dog over her head like a championship trophy. Victoria is screaming. Emma, crying, is still updating her spreadsheet with one hand.

EMMA
(sobbing, typing)
Two-sixty-two... approximately...

HARMONY
Emma, baby, you can stop counting for one second.

EMMA
No, I can't. It's very important.

INT. SHRINE — WAR ROOM — CONTINUOUS

Pandemonium. Grace is jumping on the velvet chaise. Tayia is hugging Arianna, who is crying into the black trench coat. Elxa is standing perfectly still with both hands over her mouth.

Patti takes off her headset. Sets it down on the makeup counter. Rubs her eyes.

PATTI
Okay. Okay. California. That's the big one. That's the split plus. That's a lead.

Marc is standing in front of the mirror rimmed in lights. Esther in front of him, her forehead pressed against his.

ESTHER
You're winning.

MARC
We're winning.

ESTHER
You're winning California, Marc. Where we met. Where the girls were born. Where Lyric asked you.

MARC
I know.

ESTHER
Go tell them.

PATTI
NOT YET. Virginia's still out. If he wins Virginia, the narrative is "Biden holds the South and the Old Dominion." If we win Virginia, the narrative is "Bullock cracks the firewall." You don't give the speech until we know which story it is.

MARC
Patti, Virginia could take till two in the morning.

PATTI
Then you'll talk at two in the morning.

MARC
There are seven thousand people out there and three of them are children with a school day tomorrow. Two of them are mine. One's my goddaughter, and she's holding a dog over her head. I'm going out there now.

Patti opens her mouth to argue. Elxa catches her eye. Shakes her head once: you won't win this one.

PATTI
(sighing)
...Fine. But you don't say the word "firewall." You don't say "Virginia." You thank California, you talk about the delegates, you get off the stage. And no "Bet" until the end.

MARC
Deal.

PATTI
Say it like you mean it.

MARC
Patti Grove, I will not say "firewall."

INT. SHRINE AUDITORIUM — MAIN STAGE — NIGHT

SUPER: 8:21 PM PST / 11:21 PM EST

"Ain't No Mountain High Enough" again; it's become the anthem. Marc walks onstage with Esther. Behind him, Amond, Elxa, Grace, Arianna, and Tayia. And then, after a beat, Emma, Victoria, and Lyric come running across the stage from the wings, shepherded by Harmony and a Secret Service agent, and grab his legs.

The crowd loses its collective mind.

Marc lifts Lyric onto his hip. She is still holding the dog. He takes the microphone with his free hand.

MARC
California!

ROAR.

MARC
I was born at Cedars-Sinai. Seven miles from this stage. I grew up in Baldwin Hills. I learned to act at a Donohue soundstage in Burbank. I got married at the Sunrise Tower in Anaheim. My kids were born here. My goddaughter, who you might remember asked me a question at her ninth birthday party —

(screaming from the crowd)
— right, Lyric? —

LYRIC
(into the mic, still holding the dog)
HI.

The crowd LOSES IT.

MARC
— she lives here. This is home. And tonight, home said yes.

Applause.

MARC
I want to say thank you to President Biden. He won tonight too. In North Carolina, in Tennessee, in Arkansas, in Oklahoma. And in Alabama, where I couldn't even be on the ballot. I respect him. I respect the people who voted for him. Especially the grandmothers. Especially the church mothers in the Carolinas who've been voting since before I was born, and who've been told their whole lives that young folks don't respect them.

(beat)
I respect you. I want to earn you. And I'm coming to your churches. Not to take anything. To listen.

A long, respectful applause. In the war room, Patti nods slowly at the monitor. Good.

MARC
Tonight we won California. We won Texas, with the help of a lot of Republicans who I bet never thought they'd vote in a Democratic primary.

(beat)
Shout-out to Roy Chapman in Houston. Don't make it a whole thing.

Laughter. In Houston, Roy, watching, puts his face in his hands. Tyler cackles.

MARC
We won Colorado and Minnesota and Massachusetts and Iowa and Maine and Utah and Vermont. And some people tonight are going to say this race is over. It isn't. Nobody can win tonight. The math doesn't allow it. And I'm glad.

(beat)
Because I don't want to win this race because of math. I want to win it because I earned it, in every state, from every voter, including the ones who didn't vote for me tonight.

(beat)
So next Tuesday: Georgia. Mississippi. Washington. A week after that: Illinois, Ohio, Florida, Arizona, Kansas. I'm going to all of them.

In the war room, Patti mouths: "Don't say firewall."

MARC
And I want to say something to my father-in-law.

Patti freezes. Elxa freezes. Grace drops a phone. Esther, on the stage beside him, goes very still, then looks up at him.

In Raleigh, Cornelius, on the edge of the hotel couch, sits up very straight.

MARC
Cornelius Smilley ran the President's campaign in North Carolina tonight. And he won. He won because he knows every pastor and every county and every church mother in the South, and he's spent fifty years earning that trust. That's not politics. That's a life's work.

(beat)
So, Dad: congratulations. You beat me in North Carolina. You earned it.

(beat, a small smile)
See you in Georgia.

The crowd ROARS. Not with hostility. With delight, the kind of roar you hear at the end of a great boxing match when two fighters touch gloves.

In Raleigh, Cornelius stares at the screen. His face is unreadable. His hand, without his permission, moves toward the framed card beside the lamp, and stops just short of it.

MARC
California. Super Tuesday...

CROWD
BET!

Confetti. Music. Lyric, on his hip, kisses him on the cheek. BET the dog barks into the microphone.

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

"SEE YOU IN GEORGIA." HE CONGRATULATED HIS FATHER-IN-LAW WHO RAN THE OPPOSITION IN NC AND THEN SAID SEE YOU IN GEORGIA. THIS IS A PRESTIGE DRAMA.

188K Retweets · 1.1M Likes

Twitter · @PattiGrove

He did not say "firewall." I'd like that noted. He did, however, say everything else I asked him not to say, and it worked. I'm going to lie down in a dressing room.

51K Retweets · 340K Likes

TikTok · @lyricsdog.bet

[Fan account; video of Lyric on stage saying "HI" into the mic while holding a terrier] "lyric baker is the real campaign manager and bet the dog is chief of staff"

22.1M views · 4.8M likes

Twitter · @CNNPolitics

Bullock, in California victory speech, congratulates father-in-law Cornelius Smilley, who led Biden's North Carolina effort: "You beat me in North Carolina. You earned it. See you in Georgia."

12K Retweets · 61K Likes

ACT THREE — "VIRGINIA"

INT. ABC NEWS ELECTION HEADQUARTERS — NIGHT

SUPER: 11:48 PM EST

The broadcast has been running nearly five hours. Ties loosened. Coffee cups everywhere. The map: almost fully colored. Only VIRGINIA (DEM) and VERMONT (GOP) remain gray.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Let's go to the map. Virginia. The last Democratic contest of the night still too close to call. With ninety-one percent of the expected vote counted, Bullock leads by fewer than six thousand votes. Fifty percent to forty-eight.

The Political Director zooms in on Virginia.

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Here's the battle. Northern Virginia, Fairfax, Arlington, Loudoun, the college towns, Charlottesville, Blacksburg: Bullock running up big margins with young voters and suburban independents. Then Richmond, Petersburg, Hampton Roads, Norfolk, the Southside: Biden, with the same kind of margins among older Black voters we saw in North Carolina.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
And what's out?

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Two things. Some mail ballots in Fairfax, which should help Bullock. And about a third of Norfolk and a chunk of Petersburg, which should help the President.

DAVID MUIR
So it could still go either way.

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
It could. And it's the one state tonight that will define the story. If the President holds Virginia, he can say he held his entire coalition from Arkansas to the Chesapeake. If Bullock takes it, the firewall cracked.

Muir glances down at a note from a producer.

DAVID MUIR
And while we wait for Virginia, the Republican race. Donald Trump is speaking at Mar-a-Lago right now, and he has won every Republican contest tonight that's been called, at least fourteen of fifteen states. The one exception still out is Vermont, where Nikki Haley is narrowly ahead.

INT. HALEY CAMPAIGN — BEACH HOUSE — KIAWAH ISLAND — NIGHT

SUPER: 11:51 PM EST

A burst of quiet cheering in the living room. On the TV: "ABC NEWS PROJECTS: HALEY WINS VERMONT (GOP)."

Simone, coming in from the deck, freezes in the doorway. A YOUNG HALEY STAFFER hugs her.

YOUNG HALEY STAFFER
We won Vermont!

SIMONE
We won Vermont.

YOUNG HALEY STAFFER
That's something, right? That's a state!

Simone looks at the map. Fourteen red states for Trump. One for Haley.

SIMONE
(gently)
It's a beautiful state. Lots of maple syrup.

The staffer's face falls a little. Simone puts a hand on her shoulder.

SIMONE
Go to bed, honey. Tomorrow's going to be a long day.

YOUNG HALEY STAFFER
Is she dropping out?

SIMONE
Go to bed.

INT. SHRINE — WAR ROOM — NIGHT

SUPER: 9:22 PM PST / 12:22 AM EST

The kids have gone home. The crowd has thinned to a few hundred diehards still in the main hall, chanting at intervals to stay awake. The war room is down to the core: Marc, Esther, Patti, Elxa, Amond, Grace, Arianna.

Patti's eyes are locked on a Virginia county map on her laptop. She hasn't blinked in what seems like minutes.

PATTI
Fairfax mail is in. We gained eleven hundred.

ELXA
Margin?

PATTI
Seven thousand two hundred. Norfolk's still out. Petersburg's still out.

AMOND
How many votes in Norfolk?

PATTI
Maybe nine thousand Democratic votes left. If he wins them seventy-thirty, that's thirty-six hundred net. Petersburg, maybe two thousand net.

ARIANNA
Fifty-six hundred. We're up seventy-two hundred.

PATTI
We're up seventy-two hundred if Norfolk breaks seventy-thirty. If it breaks eighty-twenty, it's a recount.

Marc is sitting on the floor in the corner of the dressing room, back against the wall, where he's been for an hour. Esther sits next to him. His tie is off. His jacket is off. He looks, for the first time in this campaign, exhausted.

MARC
(quietly)
If it's a recount, I'll concede it.

Everyone turns.

PATTI
You'll WHAT?

MARC
If it's under half a percent, I'll concede Virginia. I won't ask for a recount. We're not dragging Virginia through two weeks of lawyers over fifty delegates when we just won California and Texas.

PATTI
Marc, that's ninety-nine delegates, and it's the narrative of the entire —

MARC
I know what it is, Patti. And I know what it looks like when a candidate fights over every vote in a close state. We all watched it in 2020. I'm not doing that. Not to the party. Not to Virginia. Not to my father-in-law's church mothers.

Silence. Patti stares at him. Arianna has stopped writing. Elxa slowly sits down on the edge of the makeup counter.

ESTHER
(softly, to the room)
He means it.

PATTI
I know he means it. That's what terrifies me.

Grace's phone buzzes. She looks at it. Her eyes go wide.

GRACE
Norfolk. Norfolk just dumped.

Everyone lunges for a screen.

INT. ABC NEWS ELECTION HEADQUARTERS — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 12:43 AM EST

The chime. The whoosh. A tired cheer from somewhere on the studio floor.

DAVID MUIR
And ABC News can now project: Marc-Anthony Bullock has won the Virginia Democratic primary.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS PROJECTS: BULLOCK WINS VIRGINIA (DEM)

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
A margin of about six thousand votes. A little more than one percentage point, outside the range where a recount is likely. The late Norfolk vote broke for the President, but not by enough.

DAVID MUIR
So the final tally for Super Tuesday on the Democratic side?

The map, fully colored.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Marc-Anthony Bullock wins eleven of sixteen contests: California, Texas, Virginia, Massachusetts, Minnesota, Colorado, Utah, Maine, Vermont, Iowa, and American Samoa. President Biden wins five: North Carolina, Tennessee, Oklahoma, Arkansas, and Alabama. Four of those five are in the South, the heart of the President's coalition, and in Alabama Bullock wasn't even on the ballot.

The delegate graphic.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Our delegate estimate. These numbers will move as California counts over the next few weeks, but tonight it looks like this:

GRAPHIC — PLEDGED DELEGATES (ABC NEWS ESTIMATE): BULLOCK 876 · BIDEN 752 · NEEDED: 1,968

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
A lead of about a hundred and twenty-four. Significant, but not insurmountable. There are about twenty-three hundred delegates left. Bullock needs about forty-seven percent of them to get to a majority. The President needs about fifty-three percent. That's a hard road for Biden, not an impossible one.

DAVID MUIR
So no presumptive nominee tonight on the Democratic side.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
No. The race goes on. Georgia, Mississippi, and Washington State next Tuesday. Then five more states on March nineteenth. And unless something changes, this goes deep into the spring. Maybe all the way to Chicago.

DAVID MUIR
And on the Republican side?

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Trump won fourteen of fifteen. Haley won only Vermont. He can't clinch mathematically until next week at the earliest. But the question everyone is asking tonight is whether Nikki Haley wakes up tomorrow still a candidate.

INT. SHRINE — WAR ROOM — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:43 PM PST

Grace screams. Tayia, who fell asleep on the chaise, wakes up screaming because Grace is screaming. Arianna sits down on the floor. Elxa writes "VA ✓" on the whiteboard, underlines it, and then, uncharacteristically, draws a small heart next to it.

Patti doesn't celebrate. She takes off her glasses. Rubs her eyes. Looks over at Marc, still sitting against the wall.

PATTI
You'd have conceded it.

MARC
Yeah.

PATTI
Ninety-nine delegates. The narrative of the night. You'd have handed it to him.

MARC
Yeah.

Patti looks at him for a long time.

PATTI
Thirty years. Four presidential campaigns. I have never met a candidate who'd give up Virginia to keep from embarrassing his opponent's church mothers.

MARC
Is that a good thing or a bad thing?

PATTI
It's a terrible thing, strategically.

(beat)
It's also the reason I got on that plane at six in the morning.

Marc smiles. Tired. Real.

ELXA
So. Recap. One hundred twenty-four delegates up. Eleven states. California, Texas, Virginia. No presumptive. On to Georgia.

AMOND
Georgia. His house.

ESTHER
My house.

Everyone turns to look at her.

ESTHER
I was born at Grady. I was baptized at Greater Mount Calvary. I learned to read in my grandmother's parlor. Georgia isn't his house, Amond. It's mine. He just lives in it.

Marc looks up at his wife from the floor with something like awe.

MARC
Patti. Put Esther on the Georgia schedule. Every day. Every church.

PATTI
Esther, you've never campaigned for him alone.

ESTHER
I've never had to.

INT. MARRIOTT — SUITE 1104 — RALEIGH — NIGHT

SUPER: 12:51 AM EST

The aides are gone. The TV still shows the final map. Cornelius, alone, in an armchair, one lamp on. Coat on. Bag packed. Flight to Atlanta at 1 PM.

On the coffee table: the framed card. His phone. And a hotel notepad where he has written, in his precise handwriting:

INSERT — NOTEPAD: "GA — MAR 12 — 108 DEL. ESTHER?"

He looks at the last word. Taps the pen on it. Then his phone lights up. A text from "LORRAINE," the first in weeks.

> **LORRAINE — 12:52 AM EST**
>
> He congratulated you. On national television. In front of seven thousand people. Your granddaughters were on that stage. Come home, Cornelius.

He reads it. Puts the phone face-down. Sits in the dark.

Then picks it back up. Types.

> **CORNELIUS — 12:58 AM EST**
>
> I'm landing at 3:10 tomorrow.

A pause. Then he adds:

> **CORNELIUS — 12:58 AM EST**
>
> Tell Neil I'll be at dinner.

He sends it. Stares at it. Then he does something he hasn't done in years. He picks up the framed card from the twins and puts it, very carefully, inside the breast pocket of his suit jacket. Against his heart. And turns off the lamp.

PART FOUR — "THE MORNING AFTER"

INT. ABC NEWS — "GOOD MORNING AMERICA" — TIMES SQUARE — MORNING

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, MARCH 6, 2024 — 7:00 AM EST

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (63) and ROBIN ROBERTS (63), and MICHAEL STRAHAN (52), all looking as though they slept four hours, because two of them did.

ROBIN ROBERTS
Good morning, America. It's Wednesday, March sixth. Super Tuesday is in the books, and this morning, two very different races.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
On the Republican side, a sweep. Donald Trump won fourteen of fifteen states. And sources close to Nikki Haley tell ABC News she will announce this morning in Charleston that she is suspending her campaign.

CHYRON: SOURCES: HALEY TO SUSPEND CAMPAIGN THIS MORNING

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
On the Democratic side, the opposite of a sweep. Marc-Anthony Bullock won eleven contests, including California, Texas, and a razor-thin Virginia. President Biden won five, all but one in the South. Bullock leads by about a hundred and twenty-four delegates. The President's campaign released a statement just after one this morning.

Graphic of the statement text.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (V.O.)
Quote: "Tonight, voters in North Carolina, Tennessee, Arkansas, Oklahoma, and Alabama stood with the President. This race is far from over. On to Georgia." End quote.

MICHAEL STRAHAN
"On to Georgia." So he's staying in.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
He's staying in. And remember, Thursday night, tomorrow night, the President delivers the State of the Union before a joint session of Congress. Every Democrat in that chamber is going to be watching him with one question in mind.

ROBIN ROBERTS
And there's a family storyline in Georgia that's honestly better than anything Hollywood could write.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
There is. Bullock's father-in-law, Cornelius Smilley, a former Georgia congressman, is running the President's Southern strategy. Bullock's brother-in-law, Georgia State Senator Neil Smilley, endorsed Bullock last week. And Bullock's wife, actress Esther Bullock, a Smilley herself, is expected to campaign in Georgia on her own for the first time.

MICHAEL STRAHAN
Thanksgiving's gonna be wild.

ROBIN ROBERTS
Thanksgiving was ALREADY wild, Michael.

EXT. — HALEY SPEECH — CHARLESTON, SOUTH CAROLINA — MORNING

SUPER: 10:03 AM EST

A small room in Charleston. A podium. American flags. Haley, composed, delivers a short statement.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (V.O.)
Nikki Haley, in Charleston, this morning: "The time has now come to suspend my campaign." She did not endorse Donald Trump. Instead she said it is now up to him to earn the votes of those in the party and beyond it who didn't support him.

At the back of the room, against the wall, in a navy suit, arms folded, eyes wet and jaw set: Simone Smilley. When Haley finishes, Simone is the first to applaud.

CHYRON: HALEY SUSPENDS CAMPAIGN — TRUMP BECOMES PRESUMPTIVE GOP NOMINEE

EXT. — HALEY SPEECH VENUE — PARKING LOT — CHARLESTON — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 10:21 AM EST

Simone walks to her rental car. Unlocks it. Sits behind the wheel. Doesn't start it. Stares straight ahead.

Her phone rings. "MARC."

She looks at it for three rings. Answers.

SIMONE
Don't you dare gloat.

MARC (V.O.)
I'm not gloating. I'm calling to say I'm sorry.

SIMONE
You're not sorry. You won eleven states last night.

MARC (V.O.)
I'm sorry YOUR lady lost. You believed in her. I know what that feels like. I'm sorry.

Simone closes her eyes.

SIMONE
...She was smart and brave.

MARC (V.O.)
Smart and brave and wrong about almost everything. Emma told you.

SIMONE
(a laugh, half a sob)
Emma told me.

MARC (V.O.)
What are you doing next?

SIMONE
I don't know. Going home. Sleeping. Being unemployed. Being the only Republican in my family who isn't in this race.

MARC (V.O.)
Come to Atlanta.

SIMONE
Marc. I'm not campaigning for you. I'm a Republican. I'm not voting in a Democratic primary.

MARC (V.O.)
I'm not asking you to campaign. Saturday night your daddy's speaking with the President's people in Atlanta, and I'm doing a rally at Morehouse, and your sister's going to every church in Fulton County, and Neil's going to be standing next to me, and your mama's going to be pretending she's not there. And Big Mama's going to be in that parlor watching all of it.

(beat)
Somebody in your family should be in that parlor with her who isn't running anything. Come sit with your grandmother, Simone.

A long silence. Simone wipes her eyes.

SIMONE
...You're a manipulative little Kid Mayor.

MARC (V.O.)
Is that a yes?

SIMONE
It's a "my flight's at four."

She hangs up. Starts the car.

MONTAGE — THE INTERNET — MARCH 5–6, 2024

Twitter · #SuperTuesday

Trending #1 Worldwide · 6.2M Tweets

Twitter · #SeeYouInGeorgia

Trending #2 in United States · 1.4M Tweets

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

11 STATES. CALIFORNIA. TEXAS. VIRGINIA. 124 DELEGATES UP. EMMA'S SPREADSHEET HAD IT AT 118 — SHE WAS OFF BY SIX AND SHE'S MAD ABOUT IT. ON TO GEORGIA.

141K Retweets · 802K Likes

Twitter · @PoliticalWire

Biden wins NC, TN, AR, OK, AL. Bullock wins the other 11. If you'd told me in April 2023 that a 31-year-old would take Texas from a sitting President with Republican crossover votes, I'd have asked you what you were smoking. Then I'd have remembered what day it was.

18K Retweets · 92K Likes

Twitter · @VA_Insider

Bullock's team privately told reporters overnight he would NOT have requested a recount in Virginia if it had fallen under 0.5%. Not sure I've ever seen that from a candidate on a primary night.

22K Retweets · 131K Likes

Twitter · @RoyChapmanHouston (new account, 3 followers)

My son made me this account. I don't know what to post. Texas. That's my post.

412K Retweets · 2.8M Likes

Twitter · @RoyChapmanHouston's replies

@TylerChapmanMusic: "DADDY YOU HAVE 400,000 FOLLOWERS"

88K Likes

Twitter · @RoyChapmanHouston's replies

@RoyChapmanHouston: "Don't make it a whole thing."

301K Likes

Twitter · @jaxonwilde

Biden won the South. The REAL America. Bullock won a bunch of blue states and Texas Republicans who've lost their minds. Wilde Card episode 47 is up.

2,904 Retweets · 9K Likes

Twitter · @TayiaBoyd

@jaxonwilde Jaxon, Bullock won Utah. Utah. Are they also not the real America?

102K Retweets · 840K Likes

Twitter · @ArianaCummingsEsq

Alabama: 52 delegates, all to the President, under a ruling the Supreme Court vacated 18 hours before the polls opened. I'll see the DNC Credentials Committee in Chicago. Bring snacks.

33K Retweets · 201K Likes

Twitter · @SimoneSmilley

Today my candidate ended her campaign. I'm proud of her. I'm proud of every woman who's ever run for President. I'm going home to Atlanta to sit with my grandmother. That's all.

61K Retweets · 519K Likes

Reddit · r/politics

"Super Tuesday results thread: Bullock wins 11 of 16 including CA, TX, VA; Biden holds NC, TN, AR, OK, AL; no presumptive Dem nominee; Haley expected to drop"

201K upvotes · 44,102 comments · Top comment: "The most consequential primary since 1968 and the main characters are a 32-year-old comedian, an 81-year-old President, and a father-in-law with a binder."

Reddit · r/politics — reply

"how does everyone know about the binder" — "Nobody knows about the binder. It's just obvious there's a binder."

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Bullock wins 11 Super Tuesday contests including California and Texas, but Biden's Southern wins keep Democratic race alive

THE NEW YORK TIMES

A Generational Split Deepens as Bullock Takes California, Texas and Virginia

President Biden's victories across the South, powered by older Black voters, deny his young challenger a knockout.

THE WASHINGTON POST

Trump sweeps Super Tuesday as Haley prepares to exit; Democrats head for a long spring

POLITICO PLAYBOOK — WED, MAR 6

'See you in Georgia': The family feud at the center of the Democratic primary

Cornelius Smilley vs. his son-in-law, with his son and daughter on the other side.

AXIOS

By the numbers: Bullock leads by ~124 pledged delegates; Biden needs ~53% of what's left

FIVETHIRTYEIGHT

Bullock is now a clear favorite for the Democratic nomination, but it could take until June or later

FOX NEWS

Trump crushes Haley on Super Tuesday; Democrats in chaos as Hollywood billionaire leads sitting President

THE ATLANTA JOURNAL-CONSTITUTION

GEORGIA ON THEIR MINDS: Biden, Bullock Both Set Saturday Atlanta Events Ahead of State's March 12 Primary

VARIETY

Shrine Auditorium Hosts Bullock's Super Tuesday Victory Party, the Venue's First Political Rally in Decades

DEADLINE

'Kid Mayor' Streams Up 900% on Donohue+ After Super Tuesday

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER

Tyrese Avery Misses Bullock's Biggest Night Amid Mysterious 'Sabbatical' — His Reserved Seat Goes Viral

PEOPLE

Lyric Baker, 9, and Her Dog Bet Steal the Show at Bullock's Super Tuesday Party

TAG

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — DINING ROOM — CASCADE HEIGHTS, ATLANTA — NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, MARCH 6, 2024 — 7:30 PM EST

The long mahogany table. The good china, used only for Easter and funerals. Candles. Josiah's portrait watching from the parlor through the open double doors.

Odessa (95) at the head of the table. She has never once let anyone else sit there since 2009.

On her right: Lorraine (62). On her left: an empty chair.

Further down: Neil (39), in a suit and the "BET." pin. Across from him, an empty chair with a place setting.

And at the foot of the table, just arrived, still in her travel clothes, with a suitcase by the door: Simone (36).

ODESSA
He said seven thirty.

LORRAINE
He's in the driveway. He's been sitting in the car for eleven minutes.

NEIL
Maybe he's not coming in.

ODESSA
He's coming in. He's a Smilley. We sit in the car until we're ready, and then we come in like nothing happened.

The front door opens. Footsteps in the hall. Everyone at the table goes still.

Cornelius Smilley (65) appears in the dining room doorway. Overcoat over his arm. The same suit from Raleigh. He looks at the table: his mother, his wife, his son, his daughter. The two empty chairs.

A long, long silence.

CORNELIUS
Simone.

SIMONE
Daddy.

CORNELIUS
I'm sorry about your candidate.

SIMONE
I'm sorry about North Carolina.

CORNELIUS
We won North Carolina.

SIMONE
I know. I'm sorry about it anyway.

Something that is almost a smile crosses Cornelius's face and disappears.

He looks at Neil. Neil looks back. Neither of them blinks.

CORNELIUS
Neil.

NEIL
Daddy.

Odessa sets down her fork. The sound is very small and fills the entire room.

ODESSA
Cornelius Augustus. Sit down at my table.

He crosses the room. Pulls out the empty chair at Odessa's left hand. The seat he sat in for forty years, until April. He sits.

That leaves one empty chair. Across from Neil. With a full place setting. Everyone looks at it.

CORNELIUS
Who's that for?

ODESSA
That's for Esther.

Cornelius goes very still.

ODESSA
She lands Friday. She's speaking at Greater Mount Calvary on Sunday. Your father's pulpit. Pastor asked her himself. And on Friday night she's sleeping in her childhood bedroom upstairs, because I asked her to. And she said yes.

CORNELIUS
(very quietly)
She's campaigning against me in my father's church.

ODESSA
She's campaigning for her husband in HER grandfather's church. Which is also my church. Where I've been sitting in the third pew since 1952.

(beat)
You can come Sunday and sit next to me. Or you can stay home. But that chair stays set until she comes home. And she IS coming home, Cornelius. To this table. Whether you like it or not.

Cornelius looks at the empty chair for a very long time. The china. The candles. The silverware laid out for a daughter who hasn't eaten at this table since 2011.

His hand drifts to his breast pocket, where the twins' card is. He doesn't take it out. Just touches it, through the fabric.

CORNELIUS
(finally, barely audible)
...Pass the greens, Mother.

Odessa passes the greens. Lorraine closes her eyes for a moment. Simone exhales. Neil lets out a breath he's been holding for six days.

Nobody says another word for the entire meal.

Nobody needs to.

Through the double doors, from the parlor, the Reverend Doctor Josiah Smilley watches his family eat dinner together for the first time in almost a year, with one empty chair at the table waiting for Friday.

SMASH TO BLACK.

SUPER: GEORGIA PRIMARY: TUESDAY, MARCH 12, 2024 — 6 DAYS

SUPER: END OF CHAPTER SIX

CONTINUITY LEDGER — CHAPTER 6

Timeline: Mon Mar 4, 2024, 9:52 AM EST → Wed Mar 6, 2024, 7:30 PM EST (Standard Time; DST begins Sun Mar 10). **Super Tuesday: Tue Mar 5, 2024.** Poll closings (EST): VA, VT 7:00 · NC 7:30 · AL, ME, MA, OK, TN, most of TX 8:00 · AR 8:30 · CO, MN, western TX 9:00 · UT 10:00 · CA 11:00.

Ages (Mar 4–6, 2024): Marc 32 · Esther 31 · Emma & Victoria 11 · Lyric 9 · Amond 32 · Harmony 31 · Arianna 31 · Tyler 32 · Tayia 32 · Elxa 33 · Grace 29 · Natasha 52 · Robert 55 · Victor 77 · Joan 75 · Odessa 95 · Cornelius 65 · Lorraine 62 · Neil 39 · Simone 36 · Patti 60 · Dante 43 · Roy Chapman 66 · Agent Ruth Okonjo 48 (fictional, Secret Service Special Agent in Charge). Real people: David Muir 50 · George Stephanopoulos 63 · Robin Roberts 63 · Michael Strahan 52 · Biden 81 · Trump 77 · Haley 52.

Real events depicted: Trump v. Anderson, a unanimous per curiam ruling (Mon Mar 4, ~10 AM EST) that states can't enforce Section 3 against federal candidates; Trump wins 14 of 15 GOP Super Tuesday states and Haley wins Vermont; Trump speaks at Mar-a-Lago Tuesday night; Haley spends the night privately in the Charleston area; Haley suspends on Wed Mar 6 in Charleston ("The time has now come to suspend my campaign"), does not endorse, and says it's up to Trump to earn the votes, making Trump the presumptive GOP nominee; Biden's State of the Union on Thu Mar 7; Georgia, Mississippi, and Washington primaries Mar 12; IL, OH, FL, AZ, KS on Mar 19. Super Tuesday Dem delegate allocations: AL 52, AS 6, AR 31, CA 424, CO 72, IA 40, ME 24, MA 92, MN 75, NC 116, OK 36, TN 63, TX 244, UT 30, VT 16, VA 99 (total 1,420).

Our-world Super Tuesday (Dem): Bullock wins 11: CA, TX, VA, MA, MN, CO, UT, ME, VT, IA, AS. Biden wins 5: NC, TN, OK, AR, AL (Bullock off the AL ballot). Calls (EST): VT 7:00 · AL, TN, MA, ME 8:00 · AR 8:30 · CO, MN, IA 9:00 · NC (Biden) 9:47 · UT 10:00 · OK (Biden) 10:15 · TX (Bullock) 10:52 · CA (Bullock) 11:00 · VA (Bullock, ~6,000 votes, ~1 pt) 12:43 AM. Est. Super Tuesday delegates: Bullock 769, Biden 651. **Running totals: Bullock 876, Biden 752** (lead ~124; ~2,306 remain; Bullock needs ~47%, Biden ~53%). **No presumptive Democratic nominee.** Biden statement: "On to Georgia." TX: about 1 in 7 Dem primary voters were Republicans or GOP-leaning. NC: Biden won Black voters over 50 by 40+.

Our-world events: On Mon Mar 4, SCOTUS grants, vacates, and remands Bullock v. Allen (AL Secretary of State Wes Allen) in light of Trump v. Anderson, but Alabama won't reprint ballots, setting up a DNC Credentials Committee challenge over 52 AL delegates in Chicago (Aug 19). Marc votes at a Bel Air vote center (poll worker Mrs. Edna, 38 years teaching kindergarten). Roy Chapman takes the Democratic ballot (poll worker Darlene), texts Marc ("Don't make it

a whole thing"), Marc frames it next to the DOT letter, Roy recycles his TRUMP 2020 sign, and he opens a Twitter account (@RoyChapmanHouston). The election-night party is at the Shrine Auditorium, with the war room in its largest dressing room. Secret Service SAIC Ruth Okonjo. Twelve rallies in seven states in six days (including a Little Rock Waffle House). Neil told Cornelius on Thu Feb 29; Cornelius: "Then I hope it keeps you warm," which Josiah said to Cornelius in 1977 when he chose Morehouse over seminary. The "SMILLEY GRANDKIDS (NO PARENTS)" group text, started by Victoria. Marc's speech: "Shout-out to Roy Chapman," "Dad: congratulations. You beat me in North Carolina. You earned it. See you in Georgia." Marc would have conceded Virginia rather than seek a recount if the margin were under 0.5%. Esther: born at Grady, baptized at Greater Mount Calvary. She will campaign alone in Georgia, lands Fri Mar 8, sleeps in her childhood bedroom, and speaks at Greater Mount Calvary Sun Mar 10. Simone comes home to Atlanta. Cornelius comes home to dinner (Wed Mar 6) and now carries the twins' card in his breast pocket. Odessa sets a chair for Esther. Saturday Mar 9: competing Atlanta events (the Biden campaign with Cornelius; a Bullock rally at Morehouse). Tyrese's "RESERVED — SABBATICAL" seat at the Shrine. Emma's estimate was off by 6 (118 vs. 124).

Looming event (in-world): the Georgia primary, Tue Mar 12, 2024 (108 pledged delegates), and Biden's State of the Union, Thu Mar 7.